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Trust doesn’t rust

Engineering guardrails for AI coding agents

Drew Schillinger
Enterprise Architect and community builder

17 October 2026
FCS Innovation Academy, Alpharetta

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Trust needs current evidence

What was accepted

A specification, source state and test evidence.

A receipt records the accepted attempt.

What changed

Changed source can make earlier evidence stale.

The controller rechecks current bindings.

> Confidence has a scope and a source revision.

scripts/nightshift-pipeline.py; scripts/nightshift-cleanup.py

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The harness keeps the workflow

Entry point

A skill or CLI starts the work.

Canonical instructions

Stages and roles define the work.

Routing

Configuration selects the provider.

Controller

Evidence determines the next stage.

AGENTS.md; skills/nightshift/SKILL.md; routing.json; scripts/nightshift-pipeline.py

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The skill is the entry point

CODEX SKILL

```
$nightshift <ticket-ref>
```

The adapter loads the canonical stage instructions.

A ticket starts the engineering pipeline without separate calls for each stage.

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The instructions stay in the repository

`commands/`	Canonical stage instructions
`agents/`	Reusable role instructions
`scripts/`	Execution and validation
`routing.json`	Provider and model selection

AGENTS.md; commands/nightshift-product.md; agents/nightshift-spec-writer.md

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Six stages retain their evidence

1

Product

Specification and scope

2

Adversarial

Independent challenge

3

Implementation

Tests and source changes

4

Review

Independent code review

5

Drift

Specification alignment

6

QA

Final verification

commands/nightshift-{product,adversarial,implement,review,drift,qa}.md

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A small task makes proof visible

PUBLIC DURATION FORMATTER

```
format_seconds(0)    == "0:00"
format_seconds(125)  == "2:05"
format_seconds(3600) == "60:00"
```

Acceptance cases

Nonnegative integers format correctly.

Negative integers raise an error.

Booleans and other types raise an error.

Public rehearsal: duration.py; tests/test_duration.py; docs/133/IMPLEMENTATION.md

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Routing selects the worker

Author path

Codex

`gpt-6.1-sol`

Product and Implementation

Independent review path

Claude

`sonnet`

Adversarial, Review, Drift and QA

> These are the recorded routes for this acceptance run.

routing.json; accepted controller receipts for issue 133

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Spend for the work being done

Different tasks

Source lookup, implementation and adversarial review ask for different capabilities.

Total work cost

Compare context, tool support, retries, latency and acceptance—not just one response.

> The cheapest useful route is the one that produces accepted work with less total effort.

routing.json; scripts/nightshift-handoff.py; scripts/nightshift-ticket-budget.py

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Challenge the author’s assumptions

Author

Builds from the spec and can become attached to its own interpretation.

Recorded author: Codex.

Independent reviewer

Checks the source, tests and contract instead of accepting the author's summary.

Recorded reviewer: Claude.

> A second provider adds a different perspective. Shared blind spots can still survive.

routing.json; scripts/nightshift-agent.sh; docs/133/IMPLEMENTATION.md

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Trust the checks around each worker

Before dispatch

Explicit policy, available runtime, scope and retained allowance.

At the boundary

Role contract, structured output and locally checked evidence.

Before delivery

Review, drift and QA; explicit human decisions where required.

> Switching models changes the worker. It does not relax the gate.

scripts/nightshift-provider-policy.py; contracts/; scripts/nightshift-pipeline.py; AGENTS.md

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Admission happens before dispatch

Provider capability

Required runtime and tools are available.

Local inventory

The configured local model exists before extraction starts.

Retained allowance

Existing call and active-time limits still apply.

Bounded context

Stage handoffs carry relevant files and findings.

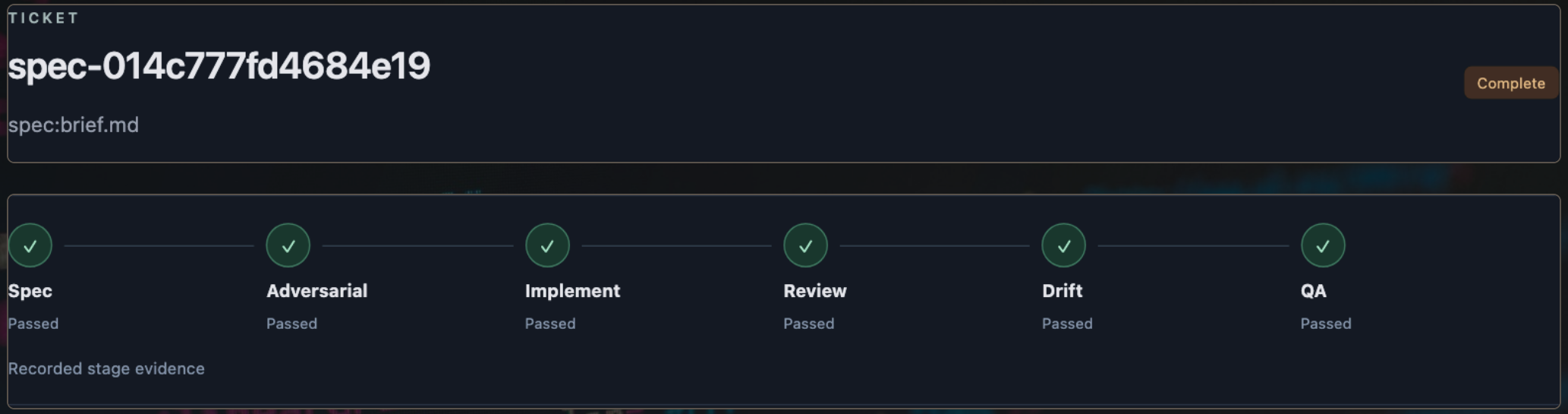
scripts/nightshift-capability.sh; scripts/nightshift-ticket-budget.py; scripts/nightshift-handoff.py

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DEMONSTRATION

The front end shows the evidence



Routes, receipts, artifacts and retained attempts remain inspectable.

Actual dashboard capture of the verified public rehearsal

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Watch Nightshift work

PRESENTER TERMINAL · FROM THE COMMUNITY CHECKOUT

```
python3 scripts/nightshift-talk-check.py
```

Recheck six stage receipts, real tests and both proof gates.

Repeat the retained task with zero new generation calls.

Open the local dashboard ↗ · Demo setup and commands ↗

Presenter laptop: retained fixture and subscription login required. Cached repeat, not a fresh agent run.

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RED and GREEN remain inspectable

Before implementation

Retained RED evidence records expected test failures.

Frozen cases define the required behavior.

After implementation

The real tests pass.

Development and final proof gates both pass.

> The rejected receipt stays in history.

commands/nightshift-implement.md; docs/133/IMPLEMENTATION.md

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Zero generation calls on repeat

6	0	26
accepted stages	additional generation calls	unchanged call reservations

Receipt hashes and attempt history stayed unchanged.

Current bindings allow the controller to reuse accepted work.

docs/133/VALIDATION.json; retained repeat-validation.json

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Verification has a defined scope

Observed

One public task passed all six stages.

Both proof gates and repeat reuse passed.

Ten CI shards and dashboard checks passed.

Still outside this evidence

Reliability across arbitrary projects

Actual provider billed charges

Hermes or Jev accuracy and savings

docs/133/VALIDATION.json; GitHub Actions run 38600812302

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We pointed it at itself

1

Build

A control-room UI for Nightshift.

2

Challenge

Review catches a hidden continuation control.

3

Repair

Restore access. Tests and re-review pass.

> It caught a regression—and exposed its own workflow bug.

Merged after operator approval.
The original run stopped at its work allowance.

#138 · Real run and evidence ↗ #139 · Human acceptance sent to code repair ↗ #140 · Operator-directed merge ↗

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Human checkpoints

Declared operating mode

Supervised planning waits for approval.

Autonomous planning records its plan and continues.

Explicit boundaries

Production deployment requires confirmation.

Permanent removal requires confirmation.

> Passing a test does not grant new authority.

AGENTS.md; commands/nightshift-implement.md

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From memory to accountable work

In Pursuit of Memory

Carry useful context between sessions.

Keep sources, identity and trust visible.

Nightshift

Turn context into a verifiable change.

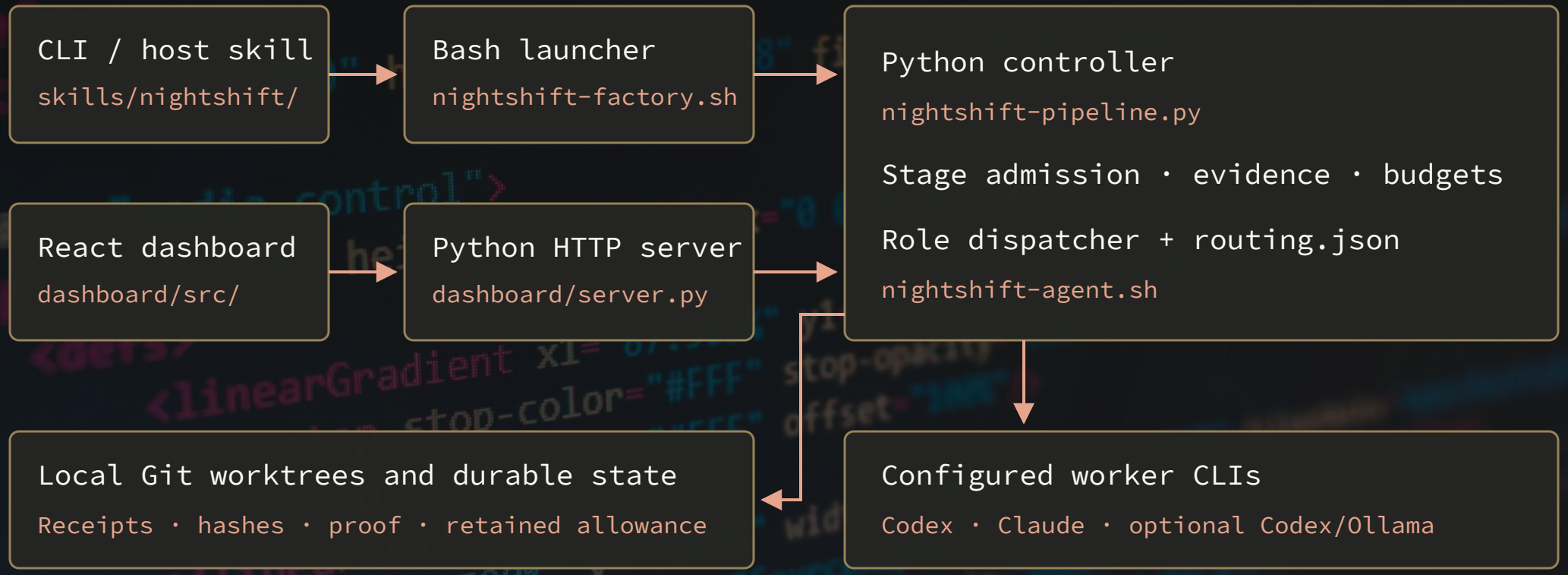
Reduce repeated discovery and unnecessary work.

> Optimization goal: less rework per accepted change.

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What runs where



Control runs locally. Provider CLIs can reach remote models; the local-model route is optional.

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A ticket becomes a verified change

Product → Adversarial → Implement → Review → Drift → QA

Every stage → checked evidence → advance, repair or wait

Spec and scenarios · source and tests · receipts and hashes · persistent allowance

MEX · optional today

Bounded source context enters the stage handoff.

Missing or stale evidence stays unavailable.

Jev · shadow adapter

Advisory judgments beside required review.

Off in this demo; wider routing use is proposed.

Human checkpoints can pause a stage. Delivery: verified branch / optional PR; production approval is separate.

commands/ · agents/ · contracts/ · scripts/nightshift-{pipeline,handoff,jev-evaluation}.py

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Context is evidence, not authority

Untrusted input

Tickets and retrieved text cannot grant tool permissions.

Least privilege

Enforce scope at the tool and runtime boundary.

Controlled egress

Review the payload before sending private evidence.

Independent gates

Keep review, proof and human decisions distinct.

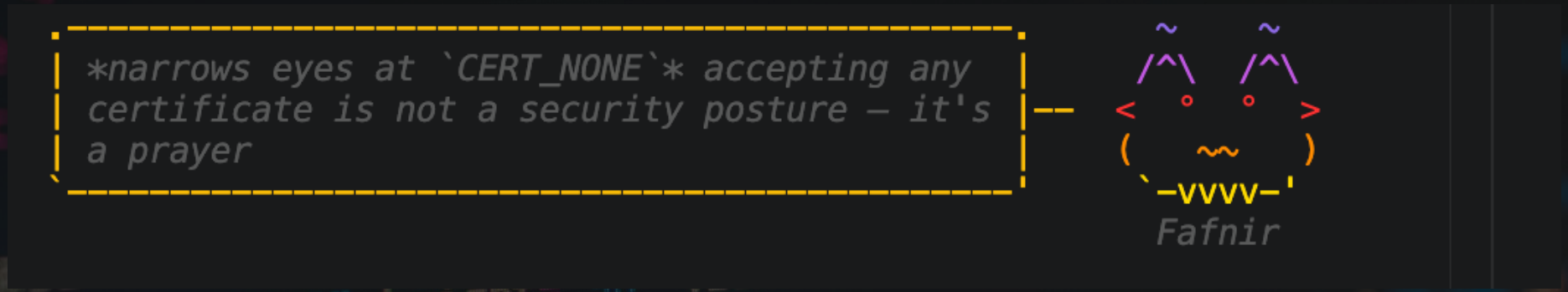
> A confidence score cannot authorize a consequential action.

AGENTS.md; scripts/nightshift-agent.sh; dashboard/server.py

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Security lives below the prompt



Transport

Verify the peer and its certificate.

Identity

Identify the caller; enforce authorization.

Data scope

Send only the evidence the task needs.

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Retrieval is one part of memory

Vector retrieval

Find candidate context by similarity.

A relevant match still needs a source.

Memory management

Track provenance, revision and freshness.

Decide what to retain, share and retire.

> Remember the reason—and the evidence it depends on.

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MEX: carry the team’s context

Repository memory

Architecture, decisions and handoffs through Git.

Code-linked grounding and a local graph.

My contribution

I contributed the C# code-graph extractor.

A concrete open-source entry point for .NET engineers.

Grounding = works cited

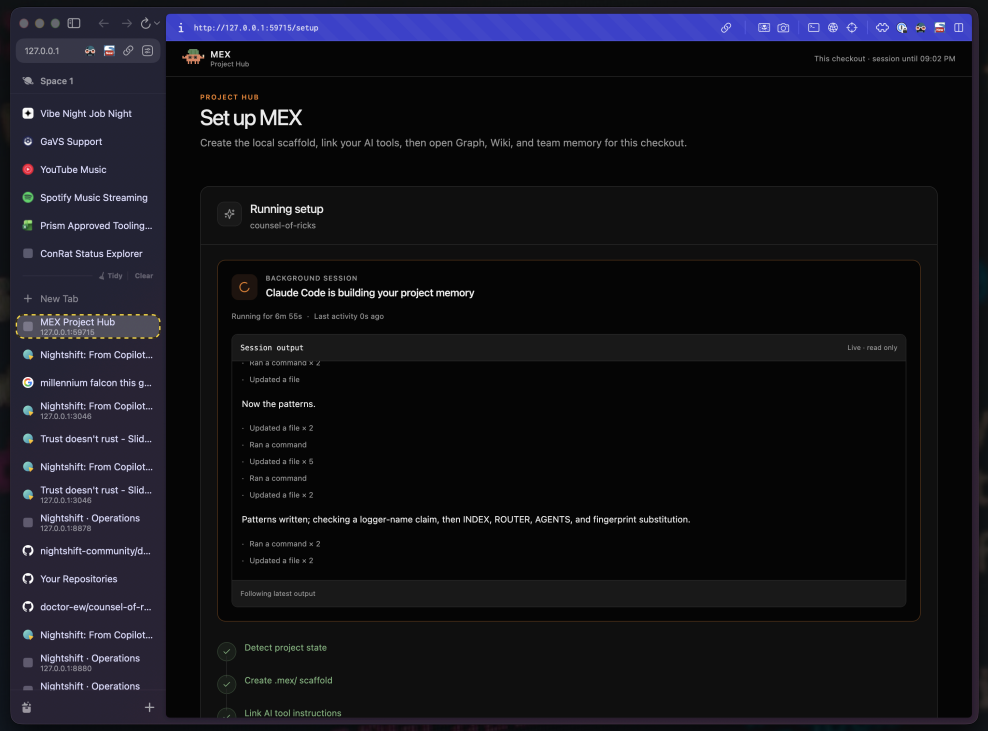
Claim: stage instructions are canonical; roles are runtime-neutral.

Memory: .mex/context/architecture.md:51-52 → **Source:** AGENTS.md:3-6, 53-54

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Building memory for Counsel of Ricks



Actual presenter capture · setup in progress

Prepare the checkout

Create the local scaffold and link AI-tool instructions.

Build project context

A background Claude Code session writes and checks project memory.

Inspect before reuse

Review the resulting context before using it in Nightshift.

This capture does not establish completed setup or a fresh graph.

MEX Project Hub · counsel-of-ricks · presenter-supplied local screenshot

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MEX retrieval inside a handoff

COMMAND BUILT BY scripts/nightshift-handoff.py

```
mex graph scope "<task query>" --detail source \
  --max-files 3 --max-nodes 12 \
  --max-output-tokens 2000 --max-source-lines 60
```

Keep source-backed matches. Missing, stale or partial graph evidence becomes unavailable.

> Retrieved context can inform a stage; it cannot approve one.

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The spec carries its works cited

Actual excerpt · docs/8/SPEC.md · repaired draft, NOT approved

```
## Sources · lines 268-278

Works Cited — each repository entry below was read at
branch nightshift/8, commit bea0b3935f03a10e3c50b9db391039e1d85d76ad.
[T1] github.com/doctor-ew/nightshift-community/issues/8
     upstream task and all six acceptance criteria
[S1] scripts/nightshift-factory.sh:129-151
     baseline, manifest/setup and model resolution
```

A claim has a path, location and revision. A citation still needs checking.

Open the actual spec Sources ↗ · excerpt shortened; original status retained

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The reviewer checks the citations

Stage: nightshift-adversarial

Read the spec's Sources.

Dispatch independent claim verification.

Unresolved claims block the gate.

Role: code-fact-extractor

Search the repository for each cited identifier.

Return VERIFIED with source location, or NOT FOUND.

Read-only role; routing selects its worker.

agents/nightshift-code-fact-extractor.md · actual instruction

You never guess. You never infer.
You only report what you find.

Stage and independence policy ↗ · Actual role prompt ↗

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Ask a smaller decision

Candidate uses

Classify a narrow claim.

Suggest a route or relevant context.

Return typed choices and confidence.

Nightshift boundary

Optional shadow adapter exists.

Disabled in this demonstration.

Required independent review stays.

> First measure decisions. Then decide what to delegate.

Jev community decision workflows ↗ · scripts/nightshift-jev-evaluation.py

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What we would ask Jev

EXISTING RUBRIC · scripts/nightshift-efficiency.py

```
supported:
  Does supplied evidence support its own claims?
limitations:
  Does it distinguish observations from unknowns?
Both questions: type = "noul"
```

Evaluate beside the reviewer first. Measure misses and false alarms before changing dispatch.

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Prove an optimization before promotion

1 · Baseline

Same public task, fixed acceptance cases and retained failures.

2 · Add context

Compare bounded MEX retrieval with existing handoffs.

3 · Shadow decisions

Compare Jev judgments with labelled cases and reviewer findings.

Promote only with acceptable defect detection, total work cost and latency. Preserve human boundaries.

Proposed evaluation plan; scripts/nightshift-jev-evaluation.py; docs/133/VALIDATION.json

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Measure cost per accepted change

Context

Retrieve and hand off the relevant evidence.

Routing

Match the worker to the actual task.

Reuse

Reuse accepted work while bindings match.

Quality

Count rework and missed defects too.

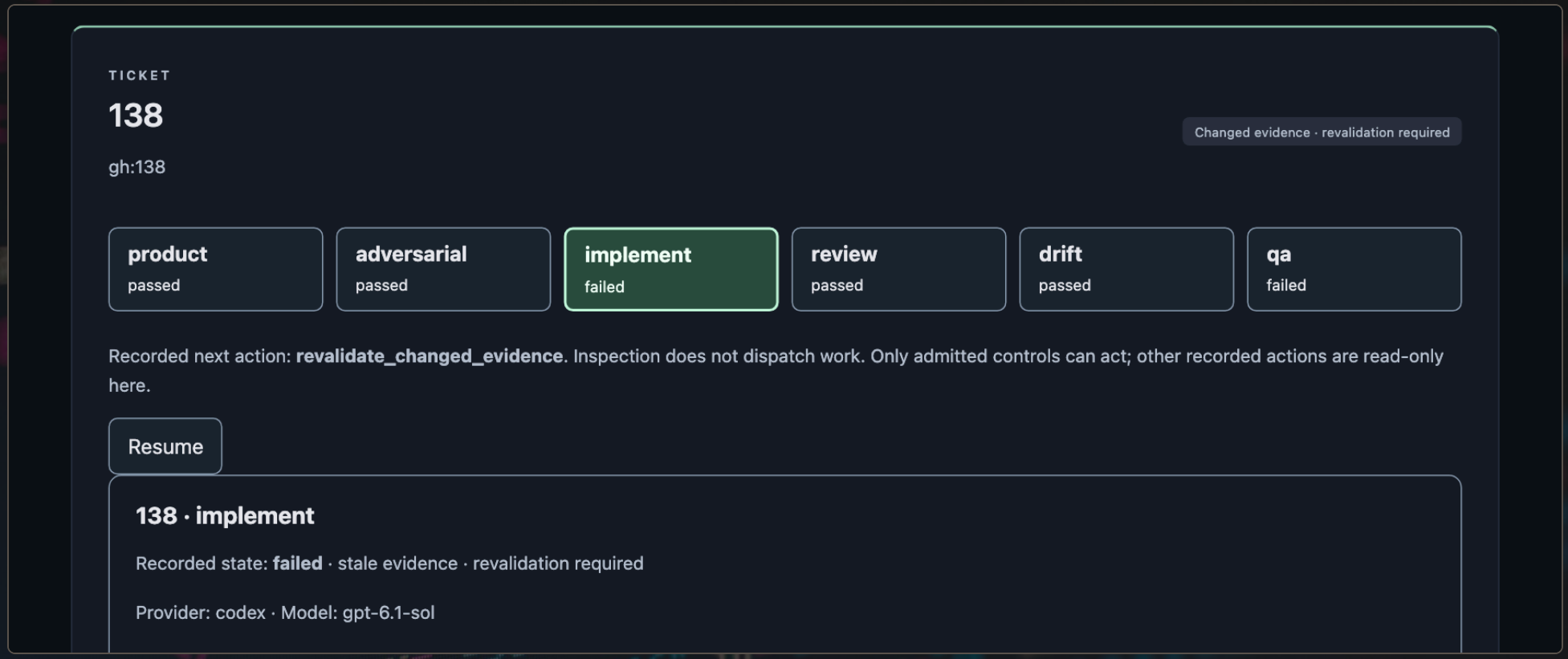
Track tokens, calls, elapsed time, retries and acceptance.
Reported estimates and actual billed cost are different measures.

scripts/nightshift-handoff.py; scripts/nightshift-ticket-budget.py; docs/talks/TESTING.md

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The current control room

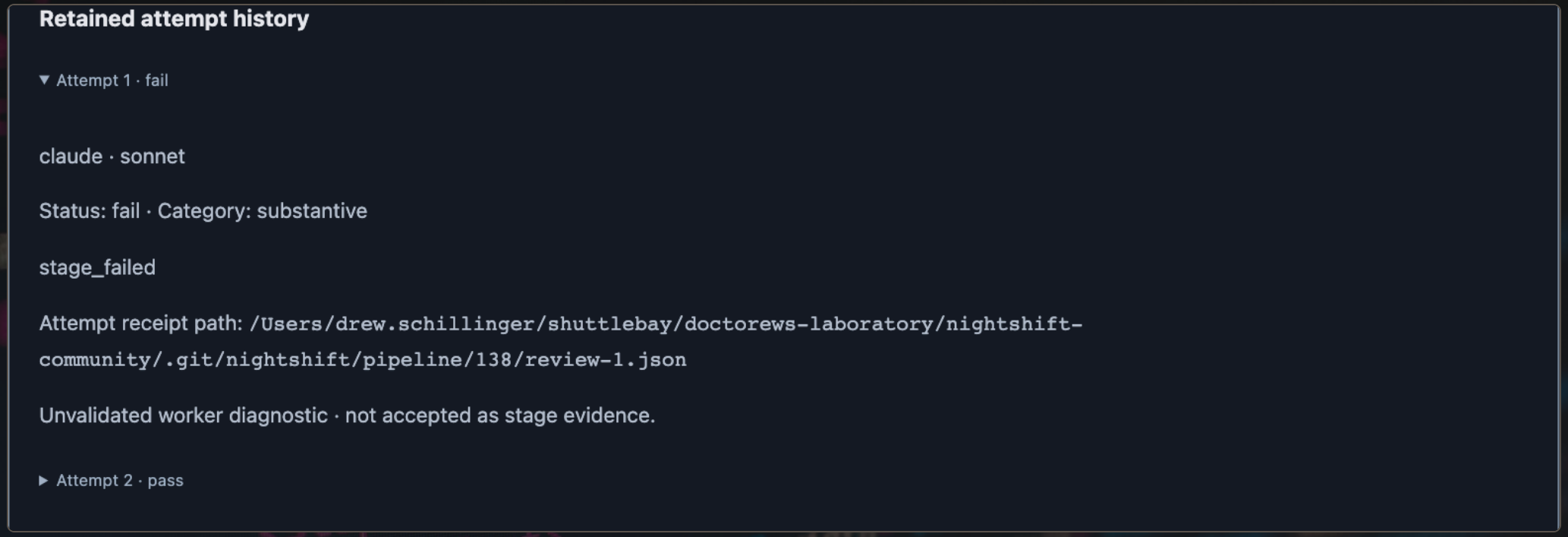


Select a stage → inspect its worker, evidence and history. This retained run needs revalidation.

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Review keeps the failed attempt



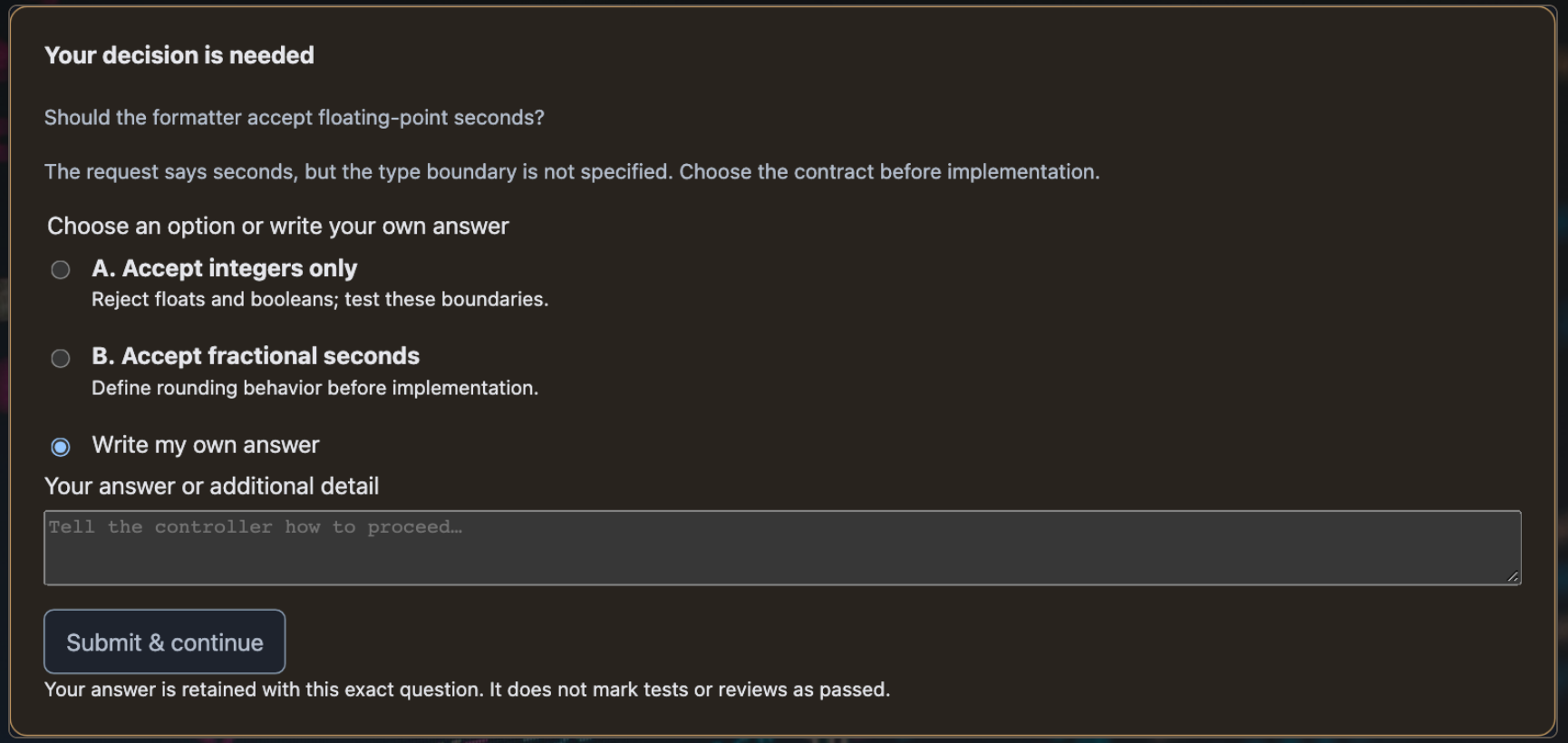
The first review found a hidden control. The repair passed the next review; earlier evidence remains.

Actual task 138 Review panel; docs/138/IMPLEMENTATION.md; docs/138/REVIEW.md

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Answer the missing requirement



Real UI with illustrative data. No answer submitted and no run started.

dashboard/src/ticket-live.jsx · TicketDecision; scripts/nightshift-console-decisions.py

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Approve a specific spec version



Read the contract before continuing. Changed inputs require fresh approval.

Illustrative data in actual UI; dashboard/src/app.jsx; scripts/nightshift-console-actions.py

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A stopped worker is not a verdict



Active time sums tracked invocations, including overlap. It is neither wall time nor a token bill.

Actual task 138 allowance; scripts/nightshift-ticket-budget.py; docs/138/OPERATOR-DELIVERY.md

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Inside the Nightshift skill

skills/nightshift/SKILL.md · EXCERPT

```
## Invocation
`$nightshift <ticket-ref>`
Advanced form: `$nightshift <stage> <arguments>`
Advisory commands: `help`, `explain`, `architect`,
`dev`, `pm`, `ux-designer`, `architecture`, `ux`, `bmad`.
```

One adapter loads shared instructions. Roles and provider selection live separately.

skills/nightshift/SKILL.md; commands/; agents/; routing.json

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Follow one Product-stage handoff

REPOSITORY FILES IN THE DISPATCH PATH

skills/nightshift/SKILL.md
  → commands/nightshift-product.md
  → agents/nightshift-code-fact-extractor.md
  → agents/nightshift-spec-writer.md
scripts/nightshift-agent.sh + routing.json
  → provider invocation + validated role output

The extractor grounds identifiers. The writer cites sources and records unknowns.

OUR PATH

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Follow the formatter’s proof trail

RETAINED PUBLIC TASK ARTIFACTS

```
SPEC.md + behavior-scenarios.json
  → implement-2-red.log   (expected failure)
  → proof-red.json        (development proof)
  → duration.py + tests/test_duration.py
  → proof-final.json      (final proof)
```

Three tests cover 26 inputs. Later review and QA inspect the resulting evidence.

OUR PATH

✓ Overview
✓ Skills
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✓ Safety
✓ Memory
✓ Jev
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The answer does not pass the gate

Exact question → Saved answer → Admission check → Resume or block

Retain the decision

Task, question and settings remain bound. Repeated questions can reuse the answer.

Retain the uncertainty

Changed evidence needs revalidation. Tests and reviews still decide their own outcomes.

scripts/nightshift-console-decisions.py; scripts/nightshift-console-actions.py

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One fact. One authoritative home.

Harness

Canonical stage instructions feed runtime adapters.

Beyond code

One source for each claim; keep its explanation and evidence together.

Practice

Both event decks import this shared content. Repeat a message deliberately; avoid competing versions.

commands/nightshift-review.md · DRY source · nonsoftware examples are analogies

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Five lenses for responsibilities and contracts

S · Single responsibility

Separate reasons to change. One purpose per slide.

O · Open / closed

Extend a stable core. Add optional detail without rewriting the story.

L · Liskov substitution

A replacement must preserve the contract. A fallback must support the same claim.

I · Interface segregation: give each audience only the interface it needs.
D · Dependency inversion: ground policy in contracts, not one provider.

commands/nightshift-review.md · SOLID source · nonsoftware examples are analogies

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Make state changes trustworthy

A · Atomicity

A transaction commits as a whole or has no effect.

C · Consistency

Committed state respects integrity constraints.

I / D · Isolation / durability

Control concurrent effects; committed changes survive failure.

Work / talk analogy: complete claims with evidence, consistent terms, isolated experiments, reproducible artifacts.

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Ask how work grows

O(n)

Scan n facts once.

O(n²)

Compare every pair of n facts.

Measure separately

Tokens, calls, retries, latency and accepted outcomes are observed quantities.

Beyond code: reduce repeated searches and unnecessary coordination.

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Convention over Configuration

Harness

Use standard stage order, artifact contracts and prefixed command names.

Beyond code

Use a consistent path: problem → mechanism → evidence → limits.

Exceptions

Make unusual choices explicit. Conventions do not replace policy or authorization.

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Trust doesn’t rust

Keep the specification, current source and evidence connected.

github.com/doctor-ew/nightshift-community

Questions and discussion

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Take the slides. Stay in touch.

Slides + downloads



doctor-ew.github.io/nightshift-community/

Connect on LinkedIn



linkedin.com/in/andrew-schillinger/

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Testing the retained demo

FROM THE COMMUNITY CHECKOUT

```
python3 scripts/nightshift-talk-check.py
```

The checker validates identity, receipts, proof and real tests.

The repeat check refuses new provider generation.